PV Narasimha Rao, a scholarly Congress veteran from the Telangana region, was a key minister under Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi. In 1991, Rao became the first politician from the south to serve as prime minister. Almost immediately, he had to deal with a severe economic crisis. Despite leading a minority government, Rao and his finance minister Manmohan Singh implemented sweeping economic reforms. Their new policies encouraged private businesses to enter sectors previously dominated by the government, made it easier for Indians to start and run businesses, and encouraged foreign investment in India. This liberalization of the Indian economy kickstarted a period of economic growth and prosperity, although not all Indians benefitted equally from it.

The illegal destruction of the Babri Masjid in Ayodhya by members of Hindu right-wing organizations occurred during Rao's tenure in December 1992. The incident triggered violent communal riots across India in which over 2000 people died and many more were injured.

ATAL BIHARI VAJPAYEE

1924–2018

